

were advised to use self checkouts or U-scan lanes to avoid getting caught at the practice of deception. Advice on the forum ranged from decoding coupons to redeem on items that weren't listed, to using it on fewer products than what was stated. For example, a coupon good for one dollar off six yogurts might actually scan on the purchase of a single yogurt, netting free yogurt. Members of the forum advocated an awareness of the "family code" in some manufacturer's coupon codes. Certain numbers on the coupon meant it didn't require verification of what it could be redeemed for. In other words, a high-value coupon meant for whitening strips could scan on a package of diaper wipes made by the same company. With these older "family codes," the register accepted the coupon on a variety of products made by the same manufacturer. That system allowed for both unintentional and intentional misredemption. Someone intent on fraudulently using one of those coupons only had to visit the website that offered a "decoder" to find out which other products the coupon worked on.

"Has decoding gone? How long will it take to crack the new code?" asked someone on the Dealideal forum in December of 2008.

The answer?

"The decoding community seems to be in deep denial about this looming catastrophe! Best I can tell from reading the UPC companies' websites, the new system cannot be manipulated because the level of specificity is very high (i.e. dates, quantities, and specific items/combinations). This means that when stores do fully switch over to the new system (i.e. program their terminals to ignore the older, decodable UPC design starting on 1/1/2010), then no "creative" coupon use will be possible! Our only hope thereafter is